

Chapter – 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Ether, air, fire, water, earth, planets, all creatures, directions, trees and plants, rivers and seas, are organs of the supreme Lord's body. – Bhāgavata Purāṇa

What is 'Sacredness'?

- Sacredness – many meanings – limited context – this chapter – something – deep religious, spiritual significance – holy, divine
- This 'something' – special location, shrine – journey – special kind (pilgrimage) – route for journey – land itself
- Sacredness – not just religion, spirituality – also geography, traditions, something more
- Every school of thought, religion – own sacred place
- Many places – visited by Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism – religions – originate outside India
- People – visit these places – pray, worship
- People – other faiths – also visit these places – Dargah Sharif, Ajmer, Rajasthan – Velankanni Church, Tamil Nadu
- Religions – originate in India – many more sacred sites
- Buddhism – places – visited by Buddha – his relics are kept
- Among them –
 - Great Stupa – Sanchi, M.P. – relic *stupa*
 - Mahabodhi Stupa – Bodh Gaya, Bihar – Buddha attained enlightenment
- These sites – imp. – pilgrimages – Bodh Gaya – 4 million+ every year
- Sikhism – *takhts* – seats, centres – spiritual authority –
 - Takht Shri Patna Sahib – Patna
 - Akal Takht – Golden Temple, Amritsar
 - Takht Shri Keshargarh Sahib – Anandpur
- Sikhs – visit these places – once in a lifetime – associated – imp. Sikh Gurus
- Sikh tradition – record pilgrimage – several Gurus – Guru Nanak – Haridwar, Prayag, Mathura, Varanasi, Ayodhya, Puri, some Muslim shrines
- India has, for ages past, been a country of pilgrimages. All over the country, you find these ancient places, from Badrinath, Kedarnath and Amarnath, high up in the snowy Himalayas down to Kanyakumari in the south. What has drawn our people from the south to the north and from the north to the south in these great pilgrimages? It is the feeling of one country and one culture. – Jawaharlal Nehru, 1961

Pilgrimages

- Many Indians – *tirthayatra*s – various sacred sites (*tirthas*) – lifetime
- Ancient, continuous tradition – not just phy. journey – also inner journey – specified code of conduct
- At least 3000 yrs. – no modern transportation – Indian – crisscrossing – Subcontinent – entire geography – sacred
- Jain tradition – *tirthas* – places – **Tirthankaras** – attain liberation – significant events
- Trees, ponds, hills, mountains – Tirthankaras visited – considered sacred – Mt. Abu, Girnar, Shatrunjaya hill

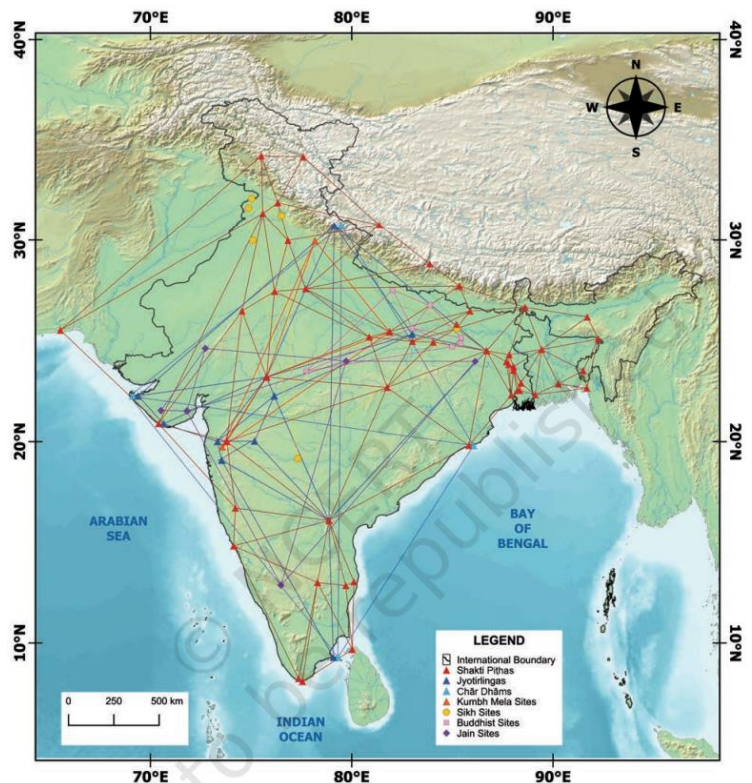
- Another example – pilgrimage – Sabarimala temple – Kerala – deity Ayyappa – 10 million + devotees every yr.
- This hilltop shrine – traditionally – very difficult trek – hills, forests
- This challenging approach – common – many shrines – hilltop, mountains – all over country – symbolize difficulties – inner path – natural landmarks – also sacred

More sacred sites

- Hindu, tribal beliefs – go further – such sys. – elements of nature – mountains, animals, trees, rivers, plants, stones – regarded sacred
- Hinduism – countless geographical sites – specific mountains, rivers, forests – regarded divine – worshipped as deities
- Many rivers – *devis* – some species – plants, animals, trees – considered holy
- This tradition – perception – divine presence – all of nature – ultimately – planet Earth – sacred – Mother Earth – Bhudevi

Becoming Aware of Sacred Geography

- Some sacred places – marked on map – spread all over India – also interconnected
- Some Hindus – aspire – *char dham yatra* – 4 sites – eastern, western, southern, northern corners – India
- Similar aspiration – 12 *jyotirlingas* – highly auspicious – 51 *Shakti pithas* – cover entire map
- These networks – crisscross – India's length, breadth – result – land – considered sacred
- Story around 51 *Shakti pithas* –
 - Shakti – divine mother – Sati – along with Shiva – insulted by her father
 - Angry Sati – killed herself – Shiva – refused – last rites
 - Shiva's anger – dangerous – world and cosmos
 - Vishnu – used chakra – cut Sati's body
 - *Shakti pithas* – places – subcontinent – body parts – divine mother – fell
- Symbol behind this story – whole land – becomes – divine mother
- Visiting major sacred places – pilgrims – naturally cover – geography – come across – diverse lang., customs, clothing, foods, commodities, etc.
- Apart from religious motivations – merchants, traders – travelled – exchange goods – others – travelled – discuss, debate, popularize – their beliefs – OR – learn, study – eminent teachers – diff. parts
- These people – travel – diff. purpose – routes converged
- Discussions, debates, goods sharing, experiences, tales – enriched everyone – new ideas emerged – old ones adapted – this process – major factor – cultural integration – Indian Subcontinent



Sacred Ecology

- *Tirthas* – located – banks of rivers, lakes – forest – mountain
- Natural landscape – perceived – sacred space – *punyakshetra*
- This perception – helps us – protect, preserve Nature
- Geography, culture, spirituality – fuse together – these kshetras

Rivers and sangams (confluence of rivers)

- Rivers – worshipped in India – Vedic times
- *Nadistuti sukta* – Rigveda – hymn (*sukta*) in praise (*stuti*) of rivers (*nadi*) – invokes – 19 major rivers – northwest India
- These rivers – lifelines – Indian civilisation – sources, tributaries, places they flow through – considered sacred, visited by pilgrims
- Local lang. – these rivers – referred with respect – Ganga ji, Yamuna ji

Kumbh mela

- Originates – legend – *amrita manthana*
- *Devas, asuras* (gods, demons) – arch enemies – joined hands – churning cosmic ocean – extract amrita – divine nectar – immortality
- Prevent asuras – getting amrita – Vishnu – Mohini form – beautiful lady – snatched the pitch (kumbha)
- This process – few drops – fell over – 4 places – Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik, Ujjain
- These places – Kumbh Mela held – dip in rivers – prescribed period – considered auspicious

Mountains and Forests

- All over world – mountains – associated with – legends, deities, heroes
- Also seen as – symbolic gateway – earth to heaven – their height
- Many *tirthas*, temples – India – hilltops – journey to these peaks – symbolic journey – reach divine
- People – undertake walk through mountain trails – these sites, shrines – tested – phy., mental abilities
- Today – such places – accessible – roads, other modes of transport

Trees, Forests and Sacred Groves

- Many parts – India – trees – offerings – turmeric, *Kumkum*
- One species – fig tree – commonly – peepul (pipal), bo tree, bodhi tree (*ashvattha* – Sanskrit) – sacred – Hinduism, Buddhism, Sikhism, Jainism
- Botanical name – *Ficus religiosa* – Latin – religious, sacred fig tree
- Previous grade – 2 epics – Mahabharata, Ramayana
- These texts – vivid descriptions – pilgrimages taken, places visited – sacred rivers, mountains, forests
- Every region – India – numerous tribal, rural traditions – claim – heroes – these texts – passed through – shrines – marking passages
- Such legends – wide diversity – communities – make the epics – their own
- Mohenjo-daro seal – leaves at top – peepul tree – imp. part – India's culture – millennia
- Rural, tribal communities – across India – protect, preserve natural forests – harmful activities – hunting, tree felling, mining



- They saw forests – abodes (homes) – deities – Ryngkew / Basa – Meghalaya
- Special forests – sacred groves – sacred status – shelter great biodiversity – flora, fauna
- Many sacred groves – home – small water bodies – help – water conservation
- 1000s of sacred groves – BUT – no. reduced – people started encroaching – agriculture, industry

From pilgrimage to trade

- Pilgrims – encounter – traders, merchants – this interactions – benefits both
- Pilgrims – need items – traders provide – result – pilgrimage, trade routes – overlap
- Some traders – double as pilgrims – taking wares – distant towns, cities – visit – sacred sites, shrines
- Uttarapatha – major trade route – connect – northwestern, eastern parts
- Dakshinapatha – Kaushambi to Pratishthana (Paithan) through Ujjayini (Ujjain)
- Some goods – traded here – precious stones – shells, pearls – coins, gold, diamonds – cotton, spices, sandalwood

Sacred Geography Beyond India

- Concept, practice – sacred geography – not unique to India
- Ancient Greece – many sacred landmarks – mountains, sacred groves
- Native Americans – special bond – nature – viewed as sacred
- Maoris – indigenous people – New Zealand – Taranaki Maunga Mountain – ancestor – hence sacred
- Many representations – Maoris – law passed – granted rights to mountain as human
- Elders – represent voice of mountain, river – threatened
- This ensures – sacred places – not exploited, degenerated

Restoring and conserving the sacred

- Harmonious relation – once existed – people and sacred geography – sustained Indian civilisation – millennia – creating values – shared all over Subcontinent – BUT – today – under great strain
- Sacred geography – relevant today – whenever – any conflict with nature – river, mountain – over exploited – people – spoken up – protect environment, deities, values